

(From right clockwise) Lockhart Bungalow, Munnar; Beach Gate Bungalows in Fort Kochi; a sumptuous lunch spread at Lockhart

At Lockhart Bungalow, a three-room British tea plantation bungalow wrapped by a pristine lawn, 1,500 acres seemed a large enough tract to lose oneself in. Colonial-era drawings of local flora and avifauna lined the walls. It felt a lot like home, for the only mealtime discussion was about what the next meal would be. Chef Arockyadoss would appear like a genie out of a tea kettle and gently announce that the consommé of the day would be Roast Cauliflower and Corn Bisque, or that luncheon featured Black Pepper Chicken Railway Curry. Jaisingh, our liveried butler, would arrange meals in the quaint dining room prettied by painted crockery, or a lovely English breakfast on the lawns, weather permitting. We were living the enchanted life of a planter on furlough…even the weather was quite sombre and English. It all made sense except for one bewildering thing—what sort of a Malayali name was Jaisingh? "Sir, I'm a local from Munnar. I was delivered by a Marwari doctor, who gave the name Jaisingh!" And then everything clicked back into place.



Manager Nizam suggested a 4-km plantation hike to acquaint us with the planters' life. Leech guards were strapped on as a precautionary measure, and it merited an introduction to local leech varieties—*kolay atta* (pond leech), *nool atta* (thread leech) and the gargantuan *aney atta* (elephant leech). The tea plantation stretched for miles and, ironically, one needed to watch out for the tinier creatures. The scourge of these hills, Arikomban, a rogue tusker who loved rice (*ari* in Malayalam), raided rice shops and killed 17 people, was relocated to Periyar last year. His replacement, Chakka Komban, loved jackfruit (*chakka*) while Padayappa, the long-tusked star named after the Rajinikanth movie, was not really harmful, but just ate his fill as he ambled from village to village. Elephants were a recurrent theme in these hills. Craig Lockhart, the estate we were exploring, was

